

Sermon Notation: "Two Men, One Gospel"

Demas, Luke, and the Question of First Love

Braselton Seventh-day Adventist Church — Sabbath Morning Sermon Preacher: Chukwuma Onyeije, MD | **Target Length:** 30 minutes

Core Thesis

Both men stood in the same room, heard the same gospel, served the same apostle, and faced the same world pulling at them. One drifted. One stayed. The difference was not talent, not theological knowledge, not even outward faithfulness. It was the location of their love. This sermon asks one question: *Where is yours?*

Central Text

2 Timothy 4:10–11 (KJV)

"For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world, and is departed unto Thessalonica; Crescens to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia. Only Luke is with me."

Full Scripture Inventory

The Demas Arc (read all three — the arc IS the argument)

| Reference | Text | Preaching Note | |---|---|---| | **Philemon 1:24** | "Marcus, Aristarchus, Demas, Lucas, my fellow labourers." | He is in Paul's inner circle — named, trusted, working. | | **Colossians 4:14** | "Luke the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you." | Named alongside Luke. No warning sign. Present. | | **2 Timothy 4:10** | "For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world." | The final mention. No drama — just absence. |

The Luke Parallel

| Reference | Text | Preaching Note | |---|---|---| | **Colossians 4:14** | "Luke the beloved physician..." | Same letter as Demas. Same standing. | | **2 Timothy 4:11** | "Only Luke is with me." | One word: *only*. The pastoral climax. |

First Love / Ephesus Parallel

| Reference | Text | Preaching Note | |---|---|---| | **Revelation 2:4–5** | "Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love. Remember therefore from whence thou art fallen, and repent, and do the first works." | The Christ-to-Ephesus diagnosis. Three commands: Remember, Repent, Return. |

Laodicean Parallel

| Reference | Text | Preaching Note | |---|---|---| | **Revelation 3:15–18** | "I know thy works, that thou art neither cold nor hot... thou art lukewarm... thou sayest, I am rich, and increased with goods, and have need of nothing... I counsel thee to buy of me gold tried in the fire..." | Demas appears in the Colossian letter; Paul tells the Colossians to share it with Laodicea. Connection is textual, not incidental. |

Supporting Texts

| Reference | Text | Use | |---|---|---| | **John 21:15–17** | "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me more than these?" | Jesus's three-question examination of Peter — love, not performance | | **Matthew 6:21** | "For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also." | The heart follows the treasure | | **Luke 9:23** | "If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me." | Luke (writer) records this; Luke (companion) lives it | | **1 John 2:15–17** | "Love not the world, neither the things that are in the world... the world passeth away, and the lust thereof: but he that doeth the will of God abideth for ever." | The theological frame for *agapē* | **Philippians 1:6** | "Being confident of this very thing, that he which hath begun a good work in you will perform it until the day of Jesus Christ." | God's intent for completion — Demas opted out | | **Matthew 24:37–38** | "But as the days of Noe were, so shall also the coming of the Son of man be. For as in the days that were before the flood they were eating and drinking..." | Not dramatic evil — comfortable distraction preceding the end |

Greek Word Studies

1. ἀγαπᾷσας — *agapas* (2 Timothy 4:10)

- **Form:** Aorist active participle of *agapaō*
- **Literal:** "having loved" — a completed action that explains his departure
- **Key:** This is the *same root word* as John 3:16 ("God so *loved* the world"), the Great Commandment ("thou shalt *love* the Lord thy God"), and John 21:15–17 (Jesus asking Peter "dost thou *love* me?")
- **Preaching move:** Paul does not say Demas feared the world, admired the world, or enjoyed the world. He *loved* it. He gave to the present age the affection that properly belongs to God.
- **Quote it directly:** "The word Paul uses is *agapas* — the word of John 3:16. The word of the Great Commandment. The word Christ asked Peter three times on the shore. He applied that word to the age that is passing away."

2. αἰῶνα — *aiōn* (2 Timothy 4:10)

- **Form:** Accusative of *aiōn*
- **Literal:** "this present age" — not merely geography or physical pleasure
- **Key:** *Aiōn* refers to the entire system of values, allegiances, and assumptions belonging to this era before Christ's return. It is the world as a rival ordering of reality.
- **Preaching move:** Demas did not necessarily become dissolute. He embraced the *aiōn* — the present world's way of measuring worth, security, and meaning.
- **Quote it directly:** "The Greek says *ton nun aiōna* — this present age. Not just pleasures. An entire rival system of meaning."

3. μόνος — *monos* (2 Timothy 4:11)

- **Form:** Nominative masculine singular adjective
- **Literal:** "only," "alone," "solitary"
- **Key:** "Only Luke is with me." The word lands like a stone. Not "chiefly" or "especially." *Only*.
- **Preaching move:** One person's faithfulness becomes, in Paul's darkest hour, the entire presence of the body of Christ. You never know when your staying will be someone's *only*.

Ellen White Citations (Verified Sources)

Primary Citations

1. Acts of the Apostles, p. 455

"Demas, who for a time had been a fellow laborer with the apostle, afterward forsook the cause of Christ. Of him Paul wrote: 'Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world.' For worldly gain, Demas bartered every high and noble consideration. How shortsighted the exchange! Possessing only worldly wealth or honor, Demas was poor indeed, however much he might proudly call his own."

Use in: The Anatomy of Drift section. Let the phrase "shortsighted exchange" land.

2. Acts of the Apostles, p. 490

"The services of Luke, the beloved disciple and faithful friend, were a great comfort to Paul and enabled him to communicate with his brethren and the world without."

Use in: The Luke section. His professional gifts were subordinated to pastoral presence.

3. Testimonies for the Church, Vol. 5, p. 161

"Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer, no time for the study of the Bible... The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity."

Use in: The diagnosis section — the modern form of Demas's drift.

4. Steps to Christ, p. 44

"It is not so much the fear of punishment, or the hope of everlasting reward, that leads the disciples of Christ to follow Him. They behold the Saviour's matchless love... and to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure."

Use in: The close — what first love actually looks like when it is alive.

5. Education, p. 57

"The greatest want of the world is the want of men—men who will not be bought or sold, men who are as true to duty as the needle to the pole."

Use in: Final closing — the call to Luke-like fidelity.

Secondary Citations (Pull as Needed)

6. Acts of the Apostles, p. 547

"The church of Ephesus had let slip her first love. She was more intent on carrying on the forms and ceremonies of religion than on possessing its spirit. She was more anxious to win the approval of men than to win the approval of God."

Use in: The Ephesus/first love section.

7. The Great Controversy, p. 508

"Satan works to distort the character of God — often making Him seem harsh or unloving — to distract humans, breaking their focus and preventing a close, personal relationship with Him."

Use in: Why drift happens — distortion precedes departure.

8. Testimonies for the Church, Vol. 4 — Laodicean eyesalve counsel (*Paraphrase:*) White's call for the church to receive the eyesalve of the Spirit, restoring the capacity to see both Christ's beauty and their own need.

Use in: The closing prescription section.

Structural Map with Timing

SECTION	CONTENT	TIME
I. THE HOOK	Paul's last dispatch; two names	3 min
II. BIBLICAL GROUND	Three Demas mentions; Luke's arc	5 min
III. ANATOMY OF DRIFT	Three diagnoses of the Demas	8 min
	(Diagnosis 1)	Urgency becomes background music
	(Diagnosis 2)	Good work replaces first love
	(Diagnosis 3)	The love question (John 21)
IV. ANATOMY OF FIDELITY	Three things Luke demonstrates	7 min
	(Luke 1)	He wrote himself out of the story
	(Luke 2)	He practiced what he documented
	(Luke 3)	He carried the "only"
V. THE INTERIOR TURN	Physician self-implication; mirror	4 min
VI. THE PRESCRIPTION / CLOSE	Remember, Repent, Return	3 min
TOTAL		30 min

Preaching Mechanics

The Staccato Kickers (deploy these at their marked moments)

1. "One man stayed. The other drifted. And the difference is the whole sermon." 2. "The most dangerous spiritual condition is not rebellion. It is comfortable productivity with a cold heart." 3. "Only Luke is with me. Three words. One lifetime of faithfulness compressed." 4. "Luke stayed. So can you. Not in your own strength. In the strength of the One who stayed for you."

The Central Preaching Contrast

| Demas | Luke | |---|---| | Loved the present age (*agapēsas ton nun aiōna*) | Loved the present Christ | | Left when it became costly | Stayed when it became lonely | | Drifted inwardly while working outwardly | Anchored inwardly while serving outwardly | | Remembered for where he went (Thessalonica) | Remembered for where he stayed (Rome) | | The word "forsaken" describes him | The word "only" describes him |

Critical Preaching Cautions

- **Do not villainize Demas.** The congregation must see themselves in him — not distance from him. He was a fellow laborer, not an apostate. The warning is the proximity.
- **The interior turn must arrive before the prescription.** If you move to "here is what to do" before you have sat with "here is who we are," the sermon becomes a lecture.
- **Do not over-taxonomize the diagnostic section.** Three diagnoses is the maximum. Each needs space to breathe, not just a label.
- **Let Luke's "only" breathe.** Do not rush past it. That word is the emotional center of the sermon.
- **The close is an invitation, not a verdict.** The tone shifts from diagnostic to pastoral in the final minutes.

Opening and Closing Moments

Recommended Opening (no warm-up — drop them in)

Begin mid-scene: Paul. Roman prison. Second imprisonment — not house arrest. Cold cell. Execution approaching. He writes what will be his last letter. And at the end of that letter, he takes attendance.

Read 2 Timothy 4:9–11 aloud. Slowly. Do not comment yet. Let it sit.

Then: "Two names. Two men. Same mission field. Same pressures. Same world pulling at both of them. One stayed. The other drifted."

Recommended Closing

Return to the scene. Not Paul's cell — but this room. This Sabbath. This congregation leaving for the world again in a few hours.

Read Revelation 2:4–5 quietly. Then: "Remember. Repent. Return. Christ does not say to the church at Ephesus: *work harder*. He says: *love Me first*."

Final line: "*Luke stayed. So can you. Not in your own strength. In the strength of the One who stayed for you.*"

Congregational Application Points (mark these for eye contact)

1. **The urgency question:** "When did you last feel the urgency you felt the first time you understood what the gospel actually meant?" 2. **The love question:** "What would you struggle to surrender if Christ asked for it this week?" 3. **The trajectory question:** "You will leave this building today and return to the *ai■n* — the present age. Which man are you becoming?" 4. **The 'only' question:** "Is there someone whose faithfulness is their *only* right now — and you are not showing up?"